

Soccer-5 League Rules Summary

August, 2025

Complete rules may be found at <https://www.soccer5clubs.org/leaguerules>.

- **JEWELRY:** No jewelry is allowed. This means no earrings, nose studs, rings, watches or necklaces. Taping over earrings is never allowed. Plugs can be worn.
- **SHIN GUARDS:** Required and must be worn inside of socks.
- **UNIFORM CONFLICTS:** If the referee determines the uniform colors are too similar, the home team will be required to change to a different color or wear pinnies. .
- **MERCY RULE:** If a team is ahead by five goals, the opponent can add a player. If they're ahead by eight goals, they can add an additional player (two total). Take those extra players off as the score gets closer.
- **PARENTS:** Parents and spectators, please stay on the opposite sideline from the teams. Coaches and players stay on their side of the field. No one is allowed behind the goal.
- **COACHES:** Only registered and approved coaches can be on the sidelines. All coaches must show their OYSA coach's card when checking in with the referee crew before each game. A picture of the coach's card on their phone is acceptable. If the coach doesn't have a card, the referee will report this back to the host club and the information will be forwarded to the coach's club. .
- **SUBSTITUTIONS:** When subbing, players need to enter the field at the midfield line, not from the bench. Wait for the ref to wave the player into the game. They can do this at any stoppage of the game; it's up to the referee.
- **MIDFIELD AREA:** Keep the area around the halfway line clear except when subbing. Coaches and players should not linger within five yards of the halfway line.
- **SLIDE TACKLES:** Not allowed at any age. A slide tackle is going to the ground to challenge for the ball. If a player goes to the ground to play the ball and no one is near them, that is not a slide tackle. The other team gets an indirect free kick, or if there is contact, a direct free kick (or penalty kick if it's within the opposing team's penalty area).
- **INTRODUCE YOURSELF:** Coaches and referees should meet before the game and address any questions or concerns and also discuss whether throw-ins will be retaken (generally only at the younger ages). For 7v7 games the referee should inform coaches whether and how the offside offense will be enforced.

League Specific Rules by Grade

High School

- 40-minute halves, 10-minute halftime
- Seven male players maximum on the field at any given time

7th and 8th grade

- 35-minute halves, 10-minute halftime

5th and 6th grade - 9v9

- 30-minute halves, 10-minute halftime
- **Penalty Kicks:** Ten yards instead of twelve
- **No deliberate headers** - Indirect free kick awarded

3rd and 4th grade - 7v7

- 25-minute halves, 10-minute halftime
- **No deliberate headers:** Indirect free kick awarded
- **Penalty Kicks:** Ten yards instead of twelve
- **Offside Rule:** May be called “loosely” in the first 2-3 weeks only .
- **Foul Throw-ins:** May be retaken by the thrower at the discretion of the referee in the first 2-3 weeks only.
- **Goalkeepers may not punt the ball:** It must be thrown or placed on the ground and kicked.
- **Build Out Rule:** On goal kicks and goalie possession, the opposing team must retreat to the halfway line. They may advance as soon as the ball is put into play.

Be Cool to the Refs!

Soccer-5 is a rec league, and we have new referees learning the ropes. Let's be patient and supportive! Spectators should never engage with the referees. Referees should never be approached after the game.

Coaches, don't argue with the referees, yell corrections, or complain about calls. You need to set an example and tone for how everyone else interacts with the referees. You can ask for an explanation nicely, but don't be distracting. Never come on to the field during a game even when play is stopped unless beckoned by the referee.

If you have advice for a referee, please resist the urge to coach them after the game. Let the assignors and mentors do that for you. Submit your feedback using this form: bit.ly/Soccer5RefereeFeedback.

Rule Clarifications for Common Situations

- **Goalie Challenges:** Don't challenge the goalie when they have the ball. If they trap it with any part of their body, including their arm, leave them alone. Our top priority is safety and protecting goalies who make themselves more vulnerable in challenges by playing with their hands in addition to their feet.
- **Goalie Challenges:** If the goalie puts the ball on the ground, then you can challenge them, and they may not pick up the ball again.
- **Goalie Handballs:** The goalie can't touch the ball when it is outside the penalty area. The referee will award a DIRECT free kick outside the penalty area when an offense occurs.
- **Drop balls:** Go to the team that last had the ball when play stopped. Everyone has to be at least five yards away. If it's in the penalty area the drop ball is awarded to the goalie and yes, they can pick it up with their hands
- **Throw-ins:** Both feet must be on the ground either on or behind the touch line. The ball must be thrown from behind and over the head. Opposing players must be at least two yards away. Foul throws may be retaken in the 7v7 games at the discretion of the referee the first 2-3 weekends of the season. Only the original thrower is allowed to take a rethrow.

NEW IN 2025-2026: Eight Second Rule

Goalkeepers may not control the ball with their hands longer than eight seconds. Referees are instructed to count down the last five seconds with a raised hand before stopping play. If a goalkeeper does not release the ball within eight seconds, play is stopped and a corner kick is awarded to the opposing team at the corner nearest to the goalkeeper at the time play was stopped.

For 7v7 games, the eight second count does not begin until the opposing team has retreated to the halfway (build out) line.

This replaces the old “six second rule” where an indirect free kick was awarded if a keeper held the ball longer than six seconds.